

# Martin Luther King, Jr.

Coretta S. King

## Introduction

Martin Luther King (1929-1968) was one of the most charismatic black leaders in U.S. history. He was a pastor of a Baptist church in Montgomery, Alabama. An untiring worker for civil rights and a powerful orator, he accepted the leadership of the first Negro non-violent demonstration in 1955 and led the black boycott of segregated city bus lines in Montgomery. The boycott lasted 382 days. During the days of boycott he was arrested, his home was bombed, he was subjected to many hardships through which he emerged as powerful black leader. He was awarded the Nobel Peace Prize in 1964. He was assassinated in Memphis, Tennessee on April 4, 1968.

## About the text

This extract from *My Life with Martin Luther King Junior* is written by his wife Coretta King. The author describes the segregation that was practiced in the city bus lines in Montgomery. She describes how the Rosa Parks incident triggered the anger of the black community. Led by the civil rights activist Martin Luther King, the blacks boycotted the buses. They had to undergo a lot of hardships but the boycott was successful and the U.S. Court declared that segregation on buses was unconstitutional.

## Reading

Of all the facets of segregation in Montgomery, the most degrading were the rules of the Montgomery City Bus Lines. This northern-owned corporation outdid the South itself. Although seventy per cent of its passengers were black, it treated them like cattle—worse than that, for nobody insults a cow. The first seats on all buses were reserved for whites. Even if they were unoccupied and the rear seats crowded, Negroes would have to stand at the back in case some whites might get aboard; and if the front seats happened to be occupied and more white people boarded the bus, black people seated in the rear were forced to get up and give them their seats. Furthermore—and I don't think Northerners ever realized this—Negroes had to pay their fares at the front of the bus, get off and walk to the rear door to board again. Sometimes the bus would drive off without them after they had paid their fare. This would happen to elderly people or pregnant women, in bad weather or good, and was considered a great joke by the drivers. Frequently the white bus drivers abused their passengers, called them black cows, or black apes. Imagine what it was like, for example, for a black man to get on a bus with his son and be subjected to such treatment.

For years Negroes had accepted this state of affairs, although with mounting anger, and then came the protest. What led to the protest was a very ordinary, almost routine, incident.

On December 1, 1955, Mrs. Rosa Parks, a forty-two-year-old seamstress, whom my husband aptly described as a charming person with a radiant personality, boarded a bus to go home after a long day working and shopping. The bus was crowded, and Mrs. Parks found a seat at the beginning of the Negro section. At the next stop more whites got on. The driver ordered Mrs. Parks to give her seat to a white man who boarded; this meant that she would have to stand all the way home. Rosa Parks was not in a revolutionary frame of mind. She had not planned to do what she did. Her cup had run over. As she said later, "I was just plain tired, and my feet hurt." So she

sat there, refusing to get up. The driver called a policeman, who arrested her and took her to the courthouse.

Word of Mrs. Parks' arrest went round rapidly among the city's black people and they decided to act. Suddenly, it seemed, nearly every Negro in Montgomery had had enough—like Mrs. Rosa Parks. The following evening a meeting of black ministers and civic leaders was held at Martin's Church. The ministers were particularly welcome. Their presence meant that they were beginning to accept Martin's view that religion must concern itself with life on earth as much as with life hereafter. From that very first step, the Christian ministry provided the leadership of the struggle, even as Christian ideals provided its inspiration. The meeting unanimously decided in favour of a boycott of buses and it was set for Monday, December 5. All the ministers present promised to urge their congregations to take part in the boycott. Several thousand leaflets were printed on the church mimeograph machine, setting out the reasons for the boycott and urging all Negroes not to ride buses "to work, to town, to school or any place on Monday, December 5".

Our greatest concern was how we were going to reach the fifty thousand black people of Montgomery, no matter how hard we worked. The white press, in an outrage exposed, spread the word for us in a way that would have been impossible with only our own resources.

On Sunday, the day before the proposed boycott, a little after midnight we finally went to bed, but at five-thirty the next morning we were up and dressed again. The first bus was due at six o'clock at the bus stop just outside our house. We had coffee and toast in the kitchen, then I went into the living room to watch. Right on time, the bus came, headlights blazing through the December darkness, all lit up inside. I shouted, "Martin! Martin, come quickly!" He ran in and stood beside me, his face lit with excitement. There was not one person on that usually crowded bus.

We stood together waiting for the next bus. It was empty too, and this was the most heavily travelled line in the whole city. Bus after empty bus paused at the stop and moved on. We were so excited we could hardly speak coherently. Finally, Martin said, "I'm going to take the car and see what's happening at other places in the city".

He picked up Ralph Abernathy and they cruised together around the city. Martin told me about it when he got home. Everywhere it was the same. A few white people and one or two blacks in otherwise empty buses. Martin and Ralph saw extraordinary sights—the sidewalks crowded with men and women trudging to work; the students of Alabama State College walking or thumbing rides; taxi cabs with people clustered in them. Some of our people rode mules; others went in horse-drawn buggies. But most of them were walking, some making a round trip of as much as twelve miles. Martin later wrote, "As I watched them I knew that there's nothing more majestic than the determined courage of individuals willing to suffer and sacrifice for their freedom and dignity."

Martin rushed off again at nine o'clock that morning to attend the trial of Mrs. Parks. She was convicted of disobeying the city's segregation ordinance and fined ten dollars and costs. Her young attorney, Fred D. Gray, filed an appeal. It was one of the first clear-cut cases of a Negro being convicted of disobeying the segregation laws—usually the charge was disorderly conduct or some such thing.

The same afternoon the leaders of the Movement met and unanimously elected Martin their president. The organization of which Martin was going to be president was called the Montgomery Improvement Association (MIA). It was decided to hold a mass meeting that night

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at which Martin was to make the main speech. Martin was determined to make his speech both militant enough to rouse people to action and devoid of hate or resentment.

Martin and Ralph went together to the meeting. When they got within four blocks of the Holt Street Baptist Church where the meeting was being held, there was an enormous traffic jam. Five thousand people stood outside the church listening to loudspeakers and singing hymns. Indeed it was so crowded, Martin told me, the people had to lift Ralph and him above the crowd and pass them from hand to hand over their heads to the platform. The crowd and the singing inspired Martin and God answered his prayer.

First the people sang "Onward, Christian soldiers" in a tremendous wave of five thousand voices. This was followed by a prayer and a reading of the Scriptures. Martin was introduced. People applauded; television lights beat upon him. Without any notes at all he began to speak. Once again he told the story of Mrs. Parks, and rehearsed some of the wrongs black people were suffering. Then he said, "But there comes a time when people get tired. We are here this evening to say to those who have mistreated us so long, that we are tired. Tired of being segregated and humiliated; tired of being kicked about by the brutal feet of oppression."

Having roused the audience for militant action, Martin now set limits upon it. His study of non-violence and his love of Christ informed his words. He said, "No one must be intimidated to keep them from riding the buses. Our method must be persuasion, not coercion. We will only say to the people, 'Let your conscience be your guide.' ... Our actions must be guided by the principles of Christian faith... Once again we must hear the words of Jesus, "Love your enemies. Bless them that curse you. Pray for them that despitefully use you."

As Martin finished speaking, the audience rose cheering in exaltation. And in that speech my husband set the keynote and the tempo of the Movement he was to lead, from Montgomery onward.

After Martin's speech the mass meeting unanimously approved the demands Ralph Abernathy had drawn up, which had to be met before we would ride the buses again. They were very moderate: 1) Courteous treatment by bus operators must be guaranteed; 2) Passengers to be seated on a first-come, first-served basis—Negroes sitting from the back forward, whites from front to back; and 3) Negro bus drivers to be employed on predominantly Negro routes.

On Wednesday, December 7, Martin met the Mayor of Montgomery, the city Commissioners and officials of the bus company to discuss terms of a possible settlement. The meeting was cordial but it came to nothing. Martin and his men now knew that they were in for a long struggle. The whites were hoping that the boycott would collapse on the first rainy day but Martin and his men had anticipated such a possibility. A car pool of voluntary drivers had been formed and pick-up stations selected throughout the city. The pool was later supplemented by station wagons bought by ten of the Negro churches with the help of the MIA.

But with all we could do, thousands of people still had to walk. They walked magnificently and proudly. Somebody asked one old grandmother, coming down the street, if she was not tired. "It used to be my soul was tired and my feet rested; now my feet's tired, but my soul is rested."

Mass meetings were held twice a week at churches in the city, to keep morale up. Thousands of people attended them, some arriving hours ahead of time to be sure of getting a seat. Martin kept a firm hand on the orators to preserve the delicate balance between inspiration and rabble-rousing. By now he was consciously emulating the Gandhian technique, and many people outside

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of the South were beginning to realize that something new was taking place in Montgomery; black people, on their own, were creating a new instrument of social change; they were building and developing a totally new kind of structure.

While it primarily helped Negroes, my husband never allowed the struggle to limit itself solely to the needs of black people. He said, "What we are doing is not only for the black man, but for the white man too. The system that has banished personality and scarred the soul of the Negro has also damaged the white man's personality, giving him a false sense of superiority as it gives the Negro a false sense of inferiority. Segregation is as bad for the one as it is for the other. So in freeing the Negro we will also free the white man of his misconceptions and his subconscious feeling of guilt towards those he wrongs."

As the days of December dragged on, and the whites saw that we would not give up, things began to get difficult. Threatening telephone calls were made to our house, any number of them. Martin was arrested on a false charge of driving above the speed limit. Then, on the night of 30 January, 1956, while he was addressing a mass meeting at the First Baptist Church, our house was bombed. Martin rushed home after the meeting. A big crowd had collected in front of the house, some of them armed with weapons. Feeling over the bombing ran high, and the white police were plainly nervous. The situation, clearly, was the first major test of Martin's leadership and of his principles, and he stood the test nobly.

Martin walked out on the porch and in a calm voice said, 'My wife and my baby are all right. I want you to go home and put down your weapons. We cannot solve this problem through retaliatory violence. We must meet violence with non-violence. Remember the words of Jesus: "He who lives by the sword will perish by the sword". We must love our white brothers, no matter what they do to us'.

After that the crowd began to thin out, and the people went back to their homes. A white policeman's voice was heard in the crowd saying, "If it hadn't been for the nigger preacher, we'd all be dead."

After the bombing things quietened for a short time and in mid-February we both were gone from Montgomery. While we were away, a Montgomery attorney had dug up an old law against boycotts, and Martin, along with ninety other leaders of the Movement, was charged. The police started making the arrests. On hearing the news we returned to Montgomery. Martin was arrested, tried and found guilty. Our lawyers not only appealed against the judgment but moved the Federal District Court in Montgomery to declare segregation on the buses unconstitutional. The case was heard on 6 May 1956. Two weeks later, the federal court held that bus segregation was unconstitutional. The city's attorneys immediately appealed to the U.S. Supreme Court. This meant that there would not be any decision for months.

Meanwhile the boycott went on with renewed enthusiasm. The attempt to break the Movement, by jailing its leaders, boomeranged. It raised the spirit of the people and brought them into even closer unity.

As autumn days came to Montgomery, the boycott still went on, but our people were growing weary. The thought of another winter of trudging through cold and slush was appalling and white resistance to the Movement had heightened. Negroes were dragged out of the car pools and badly beaten. Black-operated filling stations, which had been supplying us with gas, were bombed, and their owners were under constant harassment.

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At this point the Mayor of Montgomery and the city fathers thought of the most dangerous of all challenges to the Movement; they decided to bring action against the car pool. A hearing was set for November 13.

On the morning of November 13, Martin was in court as chief defendant. The arguments against the car pool droned on. It was just a matter of form; the judge was certain to issue an order against the car pool, and we knew it.

Then, at just about noon, there was a sudden stirring. Mayor Gayle and Commissioner Sellers abruptly left their seats, followed by two of the city's attorneys. Several reporters were rushing around. The Associated Press reporter handed Martin a slip of paper, and we were all straining to see. Martin read the note to the people at the table; then he came running back to me, his face beaming, 'Listen to this,' he said, and he read aloud, "The United States Supreme Court today affirmed a decision of a special three-judge U.S. District Court declaring Alabama's state and local laws requiring segregation on buses unconstitutional."

We had a great Christmas present that year. On December 20, 1956, the Supreme Court order reached Montgomery. That day Mayor Gayle announced that he would obey the ruling and maintain order. At a mass meeting that night, Martin announced the official end of the boycott and urged everyone to return to the buses on a non-segregated basis the next day.

The next morning, at five forty-five, a little group gathered in our living room. Mrs. Rosa Parks, Ralph Abernathy, E.D. Nixon and Glenn Smiley (who was white) came to ride the first desegregated bus with Martin. The headlights of the six o' clock bus flashed down the empty street as it pulled up at the bus stop. The men walked down the steps of our house and through the front door of the bus. The bus driver, smiling broadly, said to Martin, "I believe you are Dr. King?"

Martin said, "Yes, I am."

"We are glad to have you with us this morning", the driver said. Smiling too, his tenseness gone, Martin thanked him and sat down in a front seat beside Glenn Smiley. With a clash of gears and a puff of exhaust, the first bus pulled away as though nothing had happened. Most of the day Martin rode different buses. At his suggestion other ministers did the same. The day went off peacefully. Not a single life was lost as a result of the Montgomery Movement.